

Claude for STEM Professors

From zero to a deployed course app: the accounts, the tokens, and three projects you can put in front of students.

So, a colleague types a sentence, an app appears, and everyone claps. I have given that demo. What the demo skips is the hour of account setup that nobody enjoys and everybody survives, which is most of what this guide is. You pay that hour once.

You do not need a programming background. If you can follow a recipe and copy-paste, you can do all of this.

Version: 21 Aug 2026. I checked every click-path against the vendor docs in August 2026. Buttons wander. If something is not where I say it is, have a look at the linked docs and trust those instead. Later versions carry a later date up here so you can tell which copy you are holding.

Prefer paper? The PDF of this version is in the repo: `claude-for-stem-professors-2026-08-21.pdf`. Links print with their URLs spelled out so it still works away from a screen. Run `./build-pdf.sh` after edits to rebuild it.

The three destination projects (details in Part 6):

1. **A course website**, built and deployed to Netlify in under an hour
2. **A practice-problem app** for your subject, auto-graded, students use it before exams
3. **A Canvas assistant** that pulls your roster and assignment data and drafts announcements, running on Render

What you need

- A computer with a web browser. Parts 1 through 6 need nothing else.
- About an hour for setup, then an afternoon per project.
- Money: every service here has a free tier that is enough for these projects. Claude Pro (\$20/month) is the one upgrade worth considering if you will use this weekly.
- Coffee. I do this with a cortado at 6am, but you do you.

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Part 1: Set up Claude

1.1 Create a Claude account

1. Go to claude.ai (<https://claude.ai>).
2. Click **Continue with Google** and pick your Google account.
3. Done. You are on the Free plan.

1.2 Free vs Pro

Free is a real working tier. The difference is mostly capacity.

	Free (\$0)	Pro (\$20/month, \$17 if annual)
Usage	Limited budget that resets every 5 hours	At least 5x Free, plus a weekly cap
Chat, web search, file uploads	Yes	Yes
Projects, Artifacts, file creation	Yes	Yes
Connectors (Part 4)	Directory connectors, plus one custom connector	Directory plus custom connectors
Model choice	Current default model	Full model picker, including the strongest models
Claude Code (Part 7)	No	Yes
Advanced Research	No	Yes

I suggest starting on Free, doing Project 1, and upgrading the first time the limit stops you mid-thought. For some people that is week one. For some it never happens. This table also goes stale faster than anything else in the guide, so claude.com/pricing (<https://claude.com/pricing>) wins any argument with it.

If you do go Pro, my referral link (<https://claude.ai/referral/X0jtHxAOEA>) throws a small thank-you my way. Feel free to ignore it. The guide is the same either way.

University note. Some universities have institutional Claude for Education agreements with different data protections than a personal account. If yours does, use it, especially for anything touching Canvas (Part 3.5 explains why). Ask your IT or teaching-technology office.

1.3 Turn on network egress (do this in a browser)

One setting is easy to miss and makes a real difference. In Claude's settings you will find this:

Allow network egress

Give Claude network access to install packages and libraries in order to perform advanced data analysis, custom visualizations, and specialized file processing. Monitor chats closely as this comes with security risks.

Without it, Claude's code environment is sealed off and cannot install the libraries that most data work needs. Turn it on and it can pull down a plotting library, a PDF parser, a statistics package, whatever the job needs. For the projects here, turn it on.

Where: `claude.ai` (<https://claude.ai>) in a web browser, then **Settings**, then **Capabilities**, then scroll to the **very bottom** of the page. It is the last item.

The catch: the phone app does not show this setting at all. You have to do it once in a browser on a laptop or desktop. It then applies to your whole account, so your phone gets it too.

That warning at the end is not boilerplate. Network access means the code Claude runs for you can reach the internet, and two things follow. It installs software written by strangers, which is the same bet you make every time you install anything. And a token you pasted into that chat could in principle be sent somewhere. This is why Part 5 nags about rotating tokens. Have a look at what Claude proposes before you approve it, the way you would skim a script a student emailed you.

Part 2: Create your accounts

Three accounts, all free, all reachable with the **Continue with Google** button. Ten minutes total.

Which Google account? Your UW account works fine for all three services, and it is the simpler answer: one login you already use daily, and your .edu address qualifies you for GitHub's free education benefits. Use it.

Faculty do not change institutions often, so the "what if I leave" worry is smaller than it looks. If it does happen, GitHub lets you add a second email and switch your primary address without losing a single repo. Five minutes, on a day when you will have bigger things to sort out.

Two exceptions. Use a personal account if the work is personal (consulting, a book, anything you would rather not explain to a chair), or if your campus IT blocks third-party sign-ins, which some units do.

2.1 GitHub

GitHub stores your code and its full history. Every project in this guide lives in a GitHub repository.

1. Go to github.com/signup (<https://github.com/signup>).
2. Click **Continue with Google** and choose your account. (Google login for GitHub has existed since mid-2025; if you last looked before that, it is new.)
3. Pick a username. It is public and hard to change, so choose something you would put on a syllabus.
4. Complete the email or device verification code GitHub sends you.

Two things to do now, while you are in there. Both live in github.com/settings/security (<https://github.com/settings/security>):

- **Set a password or passkey.** Accounts created through Google have no password, which means no way in if your Google account is ever locked.
- **Turn on two-factor authentication.** GitHub will nag you about this anyway.

2.2 Netlify

Netlify hosts websites and frontend apps: your course site, your quiz app. The free tier is generous and fine for a class.

1. Go to app.netlify.com/signup (<https://app.netlify.com/signup>).

2. Click **Sign up with Google**. (GitHub, GitLab, Bitbucket, and email also work. Signing up with GitHub saves one password and makes repo linking slightly smoother later, but Google is fine.)
3. Answer or skip the onboarding questions. You land on an empty dashboard. Good.

2.3 Render

Render hosts backends: apps with a server, a database, or a secret they must keep (like your Canvas token in Project 3). Free-tier services sleep when idle and take a moment to wake up, which is fine for a personal tool. Details at render.com/docs/free (<https://render.com/docs/free>).

1. Go to dashboard.render.com/register (<https://dashboard.render.com/register>).
 2. Click the **Google** button. (GitHub, GitLab, and email also work.)
 3. Confirm your email if asked. You land on an empty dashboard.
-

Part 3: Get your tokens

A token is a password with a narrower job. It lets a program act as you on one service without ever seeing your real password. The pattern is always the same: generate a token, hand it to Claude in a chat, let Claude do the work, then delete or rotate it. Treat a token like a password. That is what it is.

Every token below is shown to you **exactly once**, at the moment of creation. Copy it somewhere safe (a password manager is the right place) before closing the page.

3.1 GitHub classic token

This is the workhorse. With it, Claude can create repositories, push code, and set up deploy pipelines on your behalf.

1. On github.com (<https://github.com>), click your profile photo (top right), then **Settings**.

2. In the left sidebar, scroll to the bottom and click **Developer settings**.
3. Click **Personal access tokens**, then **Tokens (classic)**. Direct link: github.com/settings/tokens (<https://github.com/settings/tokens>).
4. Click **Generate new token**, then **Generate new token (classic)**. GitHub may ask you to re-authenticate.
5. **Note:** name it for its job, e.g. `claude-course-projects`.
6. **Expiration:** 90 days. Do not pick "no expiration"; future-you will forget this token exists.
7. **Scopes:** check the entire **repo** box, and check **workflow**. The first lets Claude manage repositories; the second lets it set up automated deploys. Leave everything else unchecked.
8. Click **Generate token** and copy the token (it starts with `ghp_`). This is the only time you will see it.

When the token expires, generating a new one takes two minutes and the old prompts still work.

3.2 Netlify personal access token

You may not need this one. The Netlify connector in Part 4.2 uses a browser sign-in instead of a token, and that is the better path. Get a token only if you want the paste-a-token route or if a project asks for one.

1. On app.netlify.com (<https://app.netlify.com>), click your avatar, then **User settings**.
2. Click **Applications**, then under **Personal access tokens** click **New access token**. Direct link: app.netlify.com/user/applications (<https://app.netlify.com/user/applications>).
3. Name it, set an **expiration date**, click **Generate token**, copy it once.

One quirk: reset your Netlify password and every existing token dies with it.

3.3 Render API key

1. On dashboard.render.com (<https://dashboard.render.com>), open your **Account Settings** and find the **API Keys** section. Direct link: dashboard.render.com/u/settings (<https://dashboard.render.com/u/settings>).
2. Click **Create API Key**, name it, copy it once.

Note: a Render API key has broad access to your whole account, with no way to narrow it. Guard it accordingly, and prefer the browser sign-in route in Part 4.3 when you can.

3.4 Google OAuth client (for app logins)

The other credentials here let Claude act as you. This one is different: it lets *other people* prove who they are to an app you built. Project 3 uses it so your Canvas dashboard asks for a Google sign-in instead of sitting behind one shared password.

Google reorganized this console during 2025 and most guides on the web still describe the old menus. What follows is the current layout.

1. Go to console.cloud.google.com (<https://console.cloud.google.com>) and sign in. Create a project (top-left project selector, then **New project**). Name it for the app, e.g. `canvas-dashboard`. Switch to it before continuing, which is the step everyone forgets.
2. In the left menu, open **Google Auth Platform**. On a fresh project it offers a **Get started** wizard. Fill in an app name and your support email.
3. **Audience** is the one real decision. **Internal** limits sign-in to accounts in your own Google Workspace organization, which is what you want if your university runs on Google and your project sits inside its organization. If Internal is greyed out, your project is not under the org, so pick **External**. External starts in testing mode, where only the test users you list can sign in, and that is fine for a dashboard with one user.
4. Under **Data access**, add only `openid`, `email`, and `profile`. These are non-sensitive scopes, so Google will not put you through app verification. Ask for anything more and you inherit a review process you do not want.

5. If you chose External, add yourself under **Test users**.
6. Open **Clients**, click **Create client**, choose **Web application** as the type. Anything else gives you the wrong OAuth flow.
7. Under **Authorized redirect URIs**, add both of these, adjusting the hostname:
 - `http://localhost:5000/auth/callback`
 - `https://YOUR-APP.onrender.com/auth/callback`
8. Click **Create**. You get a **Client ID** (ends in `.apps.googleusercontent.com`) and a **Client secret**. Copy both. The console shows only the last four characters of the secret afterwards.

The client ID is not sensitive and ends up in your app anyway. The client secret is a real secret and belongs in an environment variable, same as every other token in this guide.

Google login alone does not protect anything. If your app accepts every Google account that signs in, you have built a door that opens for four billion people. Signing in proves identity; it does not grant permission. The app has to check the returned email against a list you control. Project 3 does this with an `ALLOWED_EMAILS` variable, and that list is the actual security boundary.

3.5 Canvas access token

A Canvas token lets a program read and write your Canvas courses through the official Canvas API. It carries **your full Canvas permissions**, which for an instructor includes student names, submissions, and grades. That is FERPA-protected data. Three rules before you generate one:

- **Check your institution's policy** on student data in external tools, AI tools included. An institutional Claude for Education account may be covered by a data agreement; a personal account is not. When in doubt, ask, or practice on a sandbox course with no real students. Instructure offers free "Free-for-Teacher" Canvas accounts for exactly this kind of practice.
- **Set an expiration date** on the token.

- **Delete the token when the task is done.** Regenerating takes one minute.

Steps:

1. Log into your institution's Canvas in a browser.
2. In the left global navigation, click **Account** (your profile picture), then **Settings**.
3. Scroll down to **Approved Integrations** and click **+ New Access Token**.
4. **Purpose:** name the task, e.g. `claude-announcement-drafts`. Set an **expiration date**.
5. Click **Generate Token** and copy it once.

If you do not see an Approved Integrations section or the button is missing, your institution has restricted self-service tokens (several universities now require a request process instead). Contact your LMS support team.

You will also need your **Canvas base URL**: the address in your browser when you use Canvas, usually `https://yourschool.instructure.com` or a custom domain like `https://canvas.uw.edu`.

Part 4: Connect Claude to your accounts

There are two ways Claude reaches your accounts, and this guide uses both.

Connectors are set up once in Claude's settings. You sign in through your browser (OAuth), no token changes hands, and you can revoke access with one click. Use these when they exist: Netlify and Render both have one.

Pasting a token in chat works for everything else. You hand Claude a token in your message, Claude uses its built-in code environment to call the service's API, done. It is cruder but universal, and you control the blast radius by controlling the token. GitHub and Canvas use this route.

One caveat about the paste route: the token sits in that conversation's history afterwards. Delete the conversation when the work is done, or rotate the token. Pick one and actually do it.

4.1 Where connectors live

- Open claude.ai/customize/connectors (also reachable via **Settings > Connectors**).
- Inside a chat, connectors are toggled per conversation: click the + (or sliders) button at the lower left of the message box, then **Connectors**.

The Free plan includes directory connectors plus **one** custom connector, which is exactly enough for this guide.

4.2 Netlify (official connector)

1. On the Connectors page, find **Netlify** in the connector directory and click **Connect**.
2. A browser window opens; sign into Netlify and click **Authorize**.
3. That is the whole setup. No token.

If Netlify is not listed in your directory, add it as a custom connector with the URL `https://netlify-mcp.netlify.app/mcp`.

Test it in a new chat: *"Using the Netlify connector, list my Netlify sites."* An empty list is the correct answer right now.

4.3 Render (custom connector)

Render's connector is added by URL. Per Render's docs (<https://render.com/docs/mcp-server>):

1. On the Connectors page, click **Add custom connector**.

2. **Name:** `render` . **URL:** `https://mcp.render.com/mcp` .
3. Open **Advanced settings** and set **OAuth Client ID** to `claude` .
4. Click **Add**, then **Connect**, and approve in the browser window that opens. No API key needed for this route.

First prompt in any chat that uses it: *"Set my Render workspace to [YOUR WORKSPACE NAME]"* (your workspace name is at the top left of the Render dashboard). Then try *"List my Render services."*

Prefer not to use a connector? Paste your API key from 3.3 into the chat instead and Claude will call the Render API directly.

4.4 GitHub (paste the token)

No connector needed. In any chat, hand Claude the classic token from 3.1 along with the task:

Here is my GitHub token: `ghp_XXXXXXXX`

Create a public repo called `test-drive` under my account, add a README that says hello, and send me the link. Do not put the token in any file.

Claude uses its code environment to run `git` and call the GitHub API with your token. That last line about not putting the token in a file is belt-and-braces. Say it anyway.

4.5 Canvas (paste the token)

Same pattern, plus the base URL:

My Canvas base URL is `https://yourschool.instructure.com`
(`https://yourschool.instructure.com`) and here is my Canvas token: `XXXX`

List my active courses with their course IDs. Read-only for now; do not change anything.

Start read-only. Once you trust the setup, you can allow writes (posting an announcement, creating an assignment) one action at a time. And per 3.5: sandbox course first, delete the token after.

Part 5: Token hygiene

Seven rules. All seven together take less time than cleaning up one compromised account.

1. **One token per purpose**, named for the job. Never reuse a token across unrelated projects.
 2. **Always set an expiration**. 90 days on GitHub, explicit dates on Netlify, Render (where offered), and Canvas.
 3. **Tokens never go in files**. Not in code, not in a README, not anywhere in a repo. Tell Claude this explicitly every time it builds something. For deployed apps, secrets belong in the hosting service's environment variables (Project 3 shows how).
 4. **Delete or rotate after a heavy session**. Especially any session where a token was pasted into chat. Rotation costs two minutes.
 5. **If a token leaks**, revoke it first and investigate second. Every service above has a revoke/delete button next to the token list.
 6. **An OAuth client secret is a token too**. Environment variable, never the repo. If it leaks, rotate it in the Google console under **Clients**.
 7. **Canvas tokens outrank the other rules**. They reach student data. Your institution's policy beats anything in this guide.
-

Part 6: Three projects

Each project has a starter prompt. Paste it into a fresh chat, fill in the CAPITALIZED bits, change whatever you like. Expect some back and forth before it is right. That is how this works.

Every starter prompt ends with "Ask me any questions before you start." Keep that line. I think it is the most useful sentence in this guide. Claude guesses when it does not know, and the guesses

are plausible and wrong in the ways that eat your afternoon: invented office hours, a 10-week schedule, some framework you never asked for. Told to check first, it comes back with three questions and then builds the thing you meant.

It runs the other way too. When something confuses you, ask. "Why React here?" "What does deploy actually mean?" "Explain that command, I do not recognize it." You cannot wear out its patience, and nobody else is watching. Treat it like a colleague who happens to have read all the documentation.

Project 1: Course website (30 to 60 minutes)

What you get. A public course site: description, schedule, office hours, policies. Version-controlled on GitHub, live on Netlify, updated by asking Claude for edits.

You need. GitHub token (3.1), Netlify connector (4.2). Enable the Netlify connector in the chat.

Start from last year's syllabus. This is the shortcut. Drag your existing syllabus into the chat (Word, PDF, or a Canvas page pasted in as text) and let Claude pull the structure out of it: description, objectives, grading breakdown, policies, weekly topics. Correcting a draft is much faster than dictating one, and the result sounds like your course because it came from your course.

No syllabus handy? The second prompt starts from a blank page. Both end up in the same place.

With a syllabus to upload:

Here is my GitHub token: PASTE_GITHUB_TOKEN

Attached is my syllabus from last year. Build a course website from it for COURSE NUMBER: COURSE TITLE, Autumn 2026.

Pull the course description, objectives, grading breakdown, and policies from the syllabus. Flag anything that looks out of date (old dates, old textbook editions, dead links) instead of copying it forward silently. Rebuild the schedule against the Autumn 2026 calendar below.

Clean and readable, works on phones, no frameworks needed. Create a public GitHub repo called COURSE-NUMBER-website under my account and push everything. Do not put the token in any file.

Then deploy to Netlify using the Netlify connector and give me the URL.

Ask me any questions before you start.

Starting from scratch:

Here is my GitHub token: PASTE_GITHUB_TOKEN

Create a public GitHub repo called COURSE-NUMBER-website under my account.

Build a course website for COURSE NUMBER: COURSE TITLE, Autumn 2026.

Pages: home (course description, instructor, office hours: YOUR HOURS), a week-by-week schedule built on the Autumn 2026 calendar below, and a policies page (late work, collaboration, AI use). Clean and readable, works on phones, no frameworks needed. Push everything to the repo. Do not put the token in any file.

Then deploy the site to Netlify using the Netlify connector and give me the live URL.

Ask me any questions before you start.

Paste this calendar block into either prompt (University of Washington, Autumn 2026):

UW Autumn 2026 quarter calendar:

- Instruction: September 30 (Wednesday) through December 11 (Friday)
- Length: 11 weeks. Note that Autumn is the long quarter at UW; Winter and Spring are 10 weeks.
- Week 1 is a partial week: Wednesday through Friday.
- Finals: December 12 through December 18
- No classes: Veterans Day, November 11 (Wednesday)
- No classes: Thanksgiving, November 26 (Thursday)
- No classes: Native American Heritage Day, November 27 (Friday)

Build the schedule around these dates. Do not schedule content or due dates on the closure days, and do not silently shift material into finals week.

Not at UW? Swap in your own calendar in the same shape. Spell out the length either way. The eleven-week Autumn quarter is a UW oddity, and left to itself Claude assumes a fifteen-week semester and hands you a schedule with four weeks that do not exist.

Then try. "Change my office hours to Wednesdays 1-3pm and redeploy." "Add a resources page with these five links." "The Thanksgiving week only has two class days, rebalance the topics." Each edit lands in the repo, so you have the full history.

Stretch. Point a custom domain at it, or ask Claude to add your publications page.

Project 2: Practice-problem app (1 to 2 hours)

What you get. An interactive quiz for your subject. Students pick answers, get instant feedback and explanations, see a score. No accounts, no server, no student data collected: it is a static page, which keeps both the engineering and the privacy story simple.

You need. Same as Project 1: GitHub token, Netlify connector.

Starter prompt:

Here is my GitHub token: PASTE_GITHUB_TOKEN

Create a public GitHub repo called SUBJECT-practice under my account. Build a single-page practice quiz app for TOPIC (e.g. "equilibrium problems in first-year chemistry"). Requirements:

- 10 multiple-choice questions with 4 options each. Write the questions at the level of AUDIENCE (e.g. "second-year undergraduates"). I will review and correct them, so make them your best attempt.
- After each answer: immediately show right/wrong plus a 2-3 sentence explanation.
- A running score and a final summary screen with a "try again" that reshuffles question order.
- Works well on phones. Store nothing about the user. No token in any file.

Push to the repo, deploy to Netlify with the Netlify connector, give me the URL.

Ask me any questions before you start.

Then try. Paste in your own question bank ("replace the questions with these 20"). Upload an old problem set or exam and ask Claude to build the quiz from those problems instead of inventing new ones. Ask for LaTeX-rendered math if your subject needs it. Ask for a topic filter if you add more questions.

Read the questions before you share the link. Claude writes plausible questions. You are the one who knows if they are right. Same review you would give a new TA's problem set, and it goes quickly. Fluency is not accuracy.

Project 3: Canvas assistant (an afternoon)

What you get. A web dashboard, hosted on Render, that talks to the Canvas API: it lists your courses, shows assignment submission counts and a grade distribution, and drafts announcement text you can paste into Canvas. Your Canvas token lives in a Render environment variable, never in the code.

You need. GitHub token (3.1), Render connector (4.3), Canvas token and base URL (3.5), Google OAuth client (3.4). Read the FERPA notes in 3.5 first. Start on a sandbox course with no real students.

Where this app lives. Free Render services are public web services. There is no private option on the free tier, so the URL is reachable by anyone on the internet who finds it, and `canvas-dashboard.onrender.com` is not hard to guess. Step 3 replaces the shared password with Google sign-in and an email allowlist, which is the difference between a locked door and a sign saying please do not enter. If the app will hold real student data, I suggest running it on your own machine instead and skipping Render entirely.

Step 1, explore in chat first (no app yet, just check the plumbing):

```
My Canvas base URL is https://YOURSCHOOL.instructure.com and here is my
Canvas token: PASTE_CANVAS_TOKEN
```

```
Read-only: list my active courses with IDs, and for course COURSE_ID
list the assignments with due dates and how many submissions each has.
```

Step 2, build and deploy:

Now build the dashboard. Here is my GitHub token: PASTE_GITHUB_TOKEN

Create a private GitHub repo called canvas-dashboard under my account. Build a small Python (Flask) web app that reads two environment variables, CANVAS_TOKEN and CANVAS_BASE_URL, and shows: my course list; per course, assignments with due dates and submission counts; per assignment, a simple grade distribution chart; and a button that drafts an announcement summarizing upcoming deadlines (draft only, nothing is posted to Canvas).

Leave authentication out for now, I will add Google login next. Do not add a password login I will have to rip out.

Never write any token or password into the code or the repo.

Then use the Render connector to create a free web service from the repo, set the environment variables (ask me for the values one at a time), deploy, and give me the URL.

Ask me any questions before you start.

Step 3, put a real lock on it:

Now the dashboard is live and anyone who finds the URL can read it. Add Google sign-in. You need the client ID and secret from 3.4 and your app's URL from Step 2, which is also the hostname to put in the redirect URI back in the Google console.

Add Google sign-in to the dashboard.

Use the OAuth authorization code flow with these environment variables: `GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID`, `GOOGLE_CLIENT_SECRET`, `ALLOWED_EMAILS` (a comma-separated list), and `FLASK_SECRET_KEY` for session signing. Request only the `openid`, `email`, and `profile` scopes.

Rules:

- Every route except the login page and the OAuth callback requires a signed-in session. Do not leave any route open.
- After Google returns the profile, check the email against `ALLOWED_EMAILS`. Anyone not on the list gets a plain "not authorized" page and no data, even though Google authenticated them fine.
- Verify the `email_verified` claim too.
- The callback path must be `/auth/callback` so it matches what I registered with Google.
- Add a sign-out route that clears the session.
- Generate a random `FLASK_SECRET_KEY` for me to paste into Render. It must not be in the code.

Then redeploy to Render, set the new environment variables, and remind me which redirect URI to add in the Google console.

Ask me any questions before you start.

Test it in a private browser window. Sign in with your own account and you should reach the dashboard. Sign in with a different Google account and you should be refused. If the second test lets you in, the allowlist is not being checked and the app is still wide open, so stop and tell Claude exactly that.

Then try. "Add a page that flags students with no submissions in the last two weeks." "Draft individual nudge emails I can review." Keep the whole thing in draft-and-review mode. The professor clicks send.

Free-tier reality. The free Render service sleeps when idle; the first load after a quiet spell takes a moment. Fine for a personal dashboard.

Part 7: Appendix, Claude Code

Everything so far runs in the `claude.ai` chat. Claude Code is the same Claude working in a terminal on your own computer: it reads and edits files in a folder, runs programs, and uses git directly.

Worth adopting when projects outgrow the chat window, when you want the files local, or when a session should pick up exactly where the last one stopped.

Two things up front. It needs a paid plan (Pro or higher, included in the subscription, so no per-use metering and no API key to look after). And it lives in a terminal, which sounds worse than it is. You type English at it, same as the chat.

Install

macOS or Linux, in Terminal:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

Windows, in PowerShell:

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

Homebrew users: `brew install --cask claude-code`.

First session

```
mkdir my-first-project && cd my-first-project  
claude
```

On first run, pick **Claude.ai account** and approve in the browser. Then just talk to it: "Build the Project 2 quiz app in this folder." It asks permission before changing files or running commands. Read what it proposes before you say yes, at least until it has earned some trust.

Connect Netlify and Render

Claude Code uses the same connectors, added from the command line:

```
claude mcp add --transport http netlify https://netlify-mcp.netlify.app/mcp  
claude mcp add --transport http --client-id claude render https://mcp.render.com/mcp
```

Then inside a session, type `/mcp` and authenticate each one in the browser. Your GitHub token gets pasted into the session the same way as in chat, or configured once with `git` credentials if you go further down this road.

Two habits

- Run `/init` in a project folder once: Claude Code writes a `CLAUDE.md` file describing the project, which future sessions read automatically. Standing instructions ("never commit tokens", "log changes in `CHANGES.md`") belong there.
- Prefer terminal-free? The Claude Code **VS Code extension** gives the same tool a graphical home.

Full documentation: code.claude.com/docs (<https://code.claude.com/docs>).

Troubleshooting

Claude says it cannot install a package, or a data-analysis step fails. Network egress is off. Turn it on in a browser: **Settings > Capabilities**, very bottom of the page (Part 1.3). The phone app does not show this setting.

Claude built something different from what you meant. You did not ask it to ask. Add "Ask me any questions before you start" and run it again. One extra exchange, and you skip the rebuild.

"Bad credentials" or 401 when Claude uses a token. The token expired, a scope is missing (GitHub needs `repo` and `workflow`), or the paste picked up a stray space. Generate a fresh one; it is faster than debugging.

Google sign-in fails with `redirect_uri_mismatch`. The URI registered in the Google console and the one your app sends have to match exactly: scheme, hostname, port, path, no trailing slash. Paste both into the chat and let Claude compare them character by character. This is the single most common OAuth error and it is always a typo.

Google says the app is unverified. Expected for an External app in testing mode. Click through the advanced link. It goes away if you switch the project to Internal, and it never applied to you in the first place if you stayed on `openid`, `email`, and `profile`.

A colleague you added to ALLOWED_EMAILS still cannot get in. On an External app they also need to be listed under **Test users** in the Google console. Two separate lists, both required.

Canvas has no "Approved Integrations" section. Your institution turned off self-service tokens. Ask LMS support. Several universities hand them out through a request form instead.

Claude ignores a connector. Enable it for that conversation: **+** button at the lower left of the message box, then **Connectors**, toggle it on. Also confirm it shows as connected on the Connectors settings page.

"Add custom connector" refuses or is missing. The Free plan allows one custom connector; remove an old one or upgrade.

Render app is slow on first load. Free services sleep when idle. It wakes on its own; wait a moment and reload.

You hit the usage limit mid-project. It resets on a rolling 5-hour window. Come back after the reset, or take it as your sign about Pro.

Everything worked yesterday and today it does not. Something upstream changed, or a token quietly expired. Paste the error into the chat and ask Claude what broke. It is better at reading its own stack traces than you would expect.

A token got committed to a repo by accident. Revoke it immediately (the service's token page has a delete button), then generate a new one. Revoking first makes the leaked copy worthless; cleaning git history is optional afterwards.

Official documentation

- Claude plans: claude.com/pricing (<https://claude.com/pricing>) · Connectors: [support.claude.com](https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11175166-get-started-with-custom-connectors-using-remote-mcp) (<https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11175166-get-started-with-custom-connectors-using-remote-mcp>)
 - GitHub accounts and tokens: [docs.github.com](https://docs.github.com/en/get-started/start-your-journey/creating-an-account-on-github) (<https://docs.github.com/en/get-started/start-your-journey/creating-an-account-on-github>) · github.com/settings/tokens (<https://github.com/settings/tokens>)
 - Netlify: [docs.netlify.com](https://docs.netlify.com/api-and-cli-guides/api-guides/get-started-with-api/) (<https://docs.netlify.com/api-and-cli-guides/api-guides/get-started-with-api/>) and the Netlify + Claude page (<https://www.netlify.com/with/claude/>)
 - Render: render.com/docs/mcp-server (<https://render.com/docs/mcp-server>) · render.com/docs/free (<https://render.com/docs/free>)
 - Canvas API and tokens: Canvas OAuth docs (<https://www.canvas.instructure.com/doc/api/file.oauth.html>) · managing access tokens (<https://community.canvaslms.com/t5/Canvas-Basics-Guide/How-do-I-manage-API-access-tokens-in-my-user-account/ta-p/615312>)
 - Claude Code: code.claude.com/docs (<https://code.claude.com/docs>)
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Version 21 Aug 2026. Maintained by Yusuf Pisan (<https://github.com/pisanuw>), pisan@uw.edu. Corrections and questions: email me or open an issue.

Written for colleagues who suspect this stuff might be useful but have not had a free afternoon to find out. Now you have a map for the afternoon. Let me know how it goes. :-)